Council of Ministers

It appears that the ministerial administration during the reign of Harsha was the same as that of the imperial Guptas. The emperor was assisted by a council of ministers(Mantri Parishad)in his duties. The council played an important role in the selection of the king as well as framing the foreign policy of the empire. The prime minister was of the most important position in the council of ministers.

Key Officials

1. Avanti	-	Minister for Foreign Relations and War
2. Simhananda	-	Commander-in-Chief
3. Kuntala	-	Chief Cavalry Officer
4. Skandagupta	-	Chief Commandant of Elephant Force
5. Dirghadhvajas	-	Royal Messengers
6. Banu	-	Keeper of Records
7. Mahaprathihara	-	Chief of the Palace Guard
8. Sarvagata	-	Secret Service Department

Revenue Administration

Bhaga, Hiranya and Bali were the three kinds of tax collected during Harsha's reign. Bhaga was the land tax paid in kind. One-sixth of the produce was collected as land revenue. Hiranya was the tax paid by farmers and merchants in cash. There is no reference to the tax Bali. The crown land was divided into four parts.

Part I - for carrying out the affairs of the state

Part II - for paying the ministers and officers of the crown

Part III - for rewarding men of letters

Part IV - for charity to religious institutions

Administration of Justice

Criminal law was more severe than that of the Gupta age. Mimamsakas were appointed to dispense justice. Banishment and the cutting of limbs of the body were the usual punishments. Trial by ordeal was in practice. Life imprisonment was the punishment for the violations of the laws and for plotting against the king.

Hieun Tsang, the Chinese pilgrim, spent nearly 13 years in India (630–643 CE), collecting sacred texts and relics which he took back to China. He was known as the" prince of pilgrims" because he visited important pilgrim centres associated with the life of Buddha. His *Si-Yu-Ki* provides detailed information about the social, economic, religious and cultural conditions during the reign of Harsha.

According to Hieun Tsang, perfect law and order prevailed throughout the empire, as the law-enforcing agencies were strong. The pilgrim records the principal penalties and judicial ordeals practised in India at that time. Corporal punishment for serious offences was in practise. But the death penalty was usually avoided. Offences against social morality and defiance of law were punished by maiming. Harsha travelled across the kingdom frequently to ensure his familiarity with his people. He was accessible to people and kept a closer watch on his tributary rulers.

Administration of Army

Harsha paid great attention to discipline and strength of the army. The army consisted of elephants, cavalry and infantry. Horses were imported. Ordinary soldiers were known as Chatas and Bhatas. Cavalry officers were called Brihadisvaras. Infantry officers were known as Baladhikritas and Mahabaladhikritas. Hieun Tsang mentions the four divisions (*chaturanga*) of Harsha's army. He gives details about the strength of each division, its recruitment system and payment for the recruits.

Division of the Empire

The empire was divided into several provinces. The actual number of such provinces is not known. Each province was divided into Bhuktis. And each Bhukti was divided into several Vishayas. They were like the districts.

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